

Leaning upon the balcony railings, the other sighed. As slim as his natural kind, his paws curled around the ~~peeling~~ ~~painted~~ metal, flakes of black paint coming off on his paws, as if he would fly away if he did not hold on, trembling to the ground from his first storey perch. His home was modest, on top of a fish and chip shop in Solihull: not the highlight of any city. His eyes looked upon ^{the} a more appealing goal of the ice hockey rink, a mere stretch of tarmac away.

It was why he watched as he did, every Thursday night without fail, for the ice hockey team to leave practice. A battered, immaculately clean

set of skates rested ~~at the ground~~
beside his booted hind paws,
ready to go. Working at the rink
allowed him the peak of skating
after hours for free, as long as
all was locked up afterwards and
there was someone else around.

Harry skated since ~~he was~~ he
could ride a bike, and doing it
better, he took ~~and~~ any chance to
practice that was offered to him.

Besides, it was free.

His tail thumped against his jean clad
calves; the players were coming
out. They laughed as they strode
into the late summer sunshine in
groups of two and three, fur
matted with sweat and bags large
enough to hold a body sling

over their shoulders. ~~He~~ The otter's eyes narrowed and he stepped back into the shadows, hugging his arms around himself. Kyle didn't have him work the nights of hockey games or practice, saying the guys were 'hard to handle'. He didn't see what was so bad about them, yet kept his distance whenever they frequented the rink. It was not his ice time anyway.

It was silly to shrink away but he kept himself well out of sight until all disappeared into cars, shouted farewells and laughter vanishing on the wind. The otter's eyes widened and a smile brightened his muzzle. They were gone! ~~Thoughts~~ Who was working? Would he have much time on the ice before the zamboni

with it all problems will be
but people who know more
will find it easier to do this
and I think you'll find many
good jobs there if you want
any of them. I'm looking for some
of the old ones but now
it looks like we are there as
much as ever and they
are all doing well.

[illegible]

was out? He would soon see.

He streaked down the steps, wrinkling his muzzle ~~and~~ at the ever present stench of greasy fish and chips. At least his flat did not reek of it. Well, not often, at least. He shook himself and hummed a song to himself, crossing the car park on light paws. Shading his eyes against the sun, he raised a paw to the glass door at the front of the orange brick building. He could not wait to feel the chill on his fur again.

"Why were you watching my team?"

The other spun on his heel, back slappping his legs. One of the ice hockey players, a grey wolf

with a creamy tone to his fur, the
hair tips to his fur naturally a
darker, gray bordering on black. He
frowned and crossed his arms over
his broad chest, hockey bag
heavy upon his shoulder.

The otter swallowed, withdrawing his
paw from the door.

⁽¹⁾One on one, ⁽¹⁾he thought. ⁽¹⁾Could
be worse... No need to over react. ⁽¹⁾

"Just waiting."

The otter stood up tall, an inch
taller than the wolf, who was
more muscular than lanky. He was
all brute strength ^{and} power, dwarfing
the otter in his shadow.

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"Every time we have practice?"

He shook his head, brown eyes skeptical - "Why? What for? Long back if you're trying to get inside information."

"What? Of course not, I'm just going to state!"

"State? Public session is closed."

"Well, what 'info' do you think I'm going to get from you? Tad paranoid."

The wolf stiffened, tail still.

"What's your name?" He asked.

"Why do you want to know?"

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